MODULE 4 · RUNWAYS AND PERFORMANCE

Lesson 18: Taxi Operations on Slippery Surfaces

Lesson 18 of 30 · about 7 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Taxi safely on contaminated aprons and taxiways.
- Avoid contaminating treated aircraft and other aircraft.
- Recognise the specific hazards of snowbanks and hidden markings.



Ramps, taxiways and ground equipment all become hazards on slippery surfaces.

Speed, spacing and thrust

- Taxi slowly, at walking pace on ice or poor surfaces. Plan turns early and make them at low speed.
- Increase the spacing behind the aircraft ahead. You need more distance to stop, and you avoid its jet blast, which blows snow, slush and ice onto your treated surfaces.
- Use the minimum breakaway thrust. High thrust on ice can make the aircraft slide or yaw.
- Make small, smooth nosewheel steering inputs. A nosewheel that skids sideways does not steer.
- If the aircraft starts to slide, reduce thrust to idle and apply braking and steering gently.

Snow and the airport environment

- **Snowbanks** along taxiway edges can strike wing tips, engine nacelles and propellers. Check the NOTAM/SNOWTAM for cleared widths.
- **Markings and lights may be covered**. Use the airport chart, request progressive taxi instructions if unsure, and confirm the holding position.
- **Ramp areas** near de-icing pads are extremely slippery because of glycol.
- Be aware of snow clearing vehicles and their crews, especially in low visibility.

Protecting the treated aircraft

- Taxi with the flaps up through slush or snow if your FCOM allows it. Set them before the runway, and complete the checklist before take-off.
- Do not taxi close behind other aircraft or through deep slush if it can be avoided.
- Monitor the precipitation and the remaining HOT while you taxi.

Single-engine taxi in winter

Single-engine taxi may be restricted in winter. Engines may need a minimum warm-up before take-off thrust, asymmetric thrust is harder to control on slippery surfaces, and starting the second engine near the runway increases workload just when the HOT is running. Follow the Operations Manual.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Slow taxi, larger spacing, minimum thrust, small steering inputs.
- Snowbanks and covered markings are hidden threats — use charts and NOTAMs.
- Keep clear of jet blast and deep slush to protect your treated surfaces.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Why should you increase spacing behind other aircraft while taxiing after de-icing?

A. To save fuel

B. To stop safely on slippery surfaces and avoid jet blast blowing contamination onto your aircraft

C. Because ATC requires double separation in winter

D. To keep the engines warm

Answer: B. Extra spacing gives you room to stop on a slippery surface and keeps you out of jet blast, which can blow snow and slush onto treated surfaces and thin the fluid.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.